

IN CONTEXT

Treading a thin line

Strauss's conduct under the Nazis has been a subject of controversy. Naively apolitical, he both loathed the regime and occasionally did their bidding, as when he conducted Wagner's *Parsifal* at the 1933 Bayreuth Festival after Toscanini withdrew in protest at the Nazis' treatment of the Jews. In mitigation, Strauss was anxious to protect his Jewish daughter-in-law, Alice, and her children. He did, though, court danger with his support of the Jewish Stefan Zweig, librettist of the opera *Die schweigsame Frau*.



A NAZI PARTY POSTER DEPICTING ADOLF HITLER, c. 1935

Richard Georg Strauss was born in Munich on June 11, 1864, the eldest child of Franz Joseph Strauss, principal horn in the city's court orchestra, and his second wife, Josephine Pschorr Strauss. The boy quickly proved something of a child prodigy, though his